

Philosophy of Religion

Religionsfilosofi

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Alte dubitat, qui altius credit.

(He doubts more deeply who believes more deeply.)

Contents

Preface to the Third Edition	5
1 Problem and Procedure	7
2 Epistemological Philosophy of Religion	17
2.1 Understanding	17
2.1.1 Causal Explanation	19
2.1.2 The World of Space	25
2.1.3 The Course of Time	31
2.2 Concluding Thoughts	31
2.3 Thought and Image	31
3 Psychological Philosophy of Religion	33
3.1 Religious Experience and Religious Faith	34
3.1.1 Religious Experience	34
3.1.2 Religious Faith	34
3.2 The Development of Religious Ideas	34
3.2.1 Religion as Drive	34
3.2.2 Polytheism and Monotheism	34
3.2.3 Religious Experience and Tradition	34
3.2.4 The Scientific Conclusion of the Psychology of Religion	34
3.3 Dogmas and Symbols	34
3.4 The Proposition of the Persistence of Value	34
3.4.1 More Precise Determination of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value and of its Relation to Experience	34
3.4.2 Psychological-Historical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value	34

3.4.3	General Philosophical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value	34
3.5	The Principle of Personality	34
3.5.1	The Significance and Justification of the Principle of Personality	34
3.5.2	Buddha and Jesus	34
3.5.3	Is the Principle of Personality a Principle of Growth or of Dissolution?	34
3.5.4	Layman and Scholar	34
4	Ethical Philosophy of Religion	35
4.1	Religion as the Foundation of Ethics	35
4.2	Religion as a Form of Spiritual Culture	35
4.2.1	Psychological Considerations	35
4.2.2	Sociological Considerations	35
4.3	Primitive Christianity and Modern Christianity	35
4.4	We Live on Realities	35
	Notes	37

Preface to the Third Edition

When I worked out my *Philosophy of Religion* in the years 1896–1901, I had not yet given any fuller account of epistemology. Nor had I arrived at one when the second edition was due to appear (1906). Later I set out my epistemological position in “The Human Thought” (1910) and in a series of investigations bearing on the subject of the present book (on Totality 1917, on Relation 1921, and on Analogy 1923). It has thereby been possible, in this third edition, to shorten the epistemological section; on several points I could now simply refer to the works named, which would otherwise have required detailed justification. Only the strictly necessary epistemological content has been retained. In the religious-psychological section too I was able to refer to works that threw light on the topics (“The Great Humour” 1916; “Experiences and Interpretations” 1918; “Leading Thoughts in the Nineteenth Century” 1920; together with the essay “Foreword and Postscript to my Philosophy of Religion,” printed in “Minor Works”). I have besides carried out a consolidation of the two groupings of religious-psychological types, determined by different points of view, between which I earlier thought it possible to distinguish. Of the notes, a number have been omitted as outdated or superfluous. Where it was necessary, I have added new notes.

The book’s fundamental thought has remained the same. Its significance has confirmed itself to me over the years by what I have experienced or learned. Often it is precisely objections that have led to fresh corroboration. The book’s fundamental thought is not a key that unlocks everywhere, but it leads one to pose fruitful questions and to enter upon investigations that one would otherwise be inclined to think superfluous. It warns against dogmatism of every kind, and it points at the same time to a deep-lying human need that can hardly die out so long as the life of the spirit is not being extinguished. It does not solve the great problem it treats, but it can lead to ever-renewed reflection. And I hope that the book will continue to work in the direction here indicated.

Carlsberg, 28 February 1924.

HARALD HØFFDING.

Chapter 1

Problem and Procedure

Οὐκ ἔστι λύειν ἀγνοοῦντα τὸ δεσμόν.

ARISTOTLE.

(One cannot loose a knot without knowing where the binding lies).

1. By *philosophy of religion* one could mean either a thinking that springs from religion and builds on religion, or a thinking that takes religion as its object. It is in this latter sense that the term shall be taken here. The thinking that springs from and builds on religion itself belongs to the subject matter of the philosophy of religion and should not be called philosophy of religion.

By religion we think first of all of a state of mind in which feeling and need, fear and hope, enthusiasm and devotion play a larger role than reflection and inquiry, and in which intuition and image hold more sway than investigation and reasoning. To be sure, again and again in the religious life there will arise an involuntary need to give an account of one's condition and of its content—of the worth of one's motives and the validity of one's thoughts. But the religious thinking that thus arises does not pose the religious problem in a decisive way. Its problems arise within religion, but religion itself does not become a problem. No other starting point is yet recognized than religion itself; in any case other starting points are so subordinate in relation to religion that they do not acquire decisive significance. Of this kind is religious thinking in those times in which religion is everything on the spiritual plane. These are the classical times of religion: partly the great times of origins, in which religion with all the power of originality draws all strength and interest to itself; partly the great times of organization, in which all existing culture is shaped or bent into obedience under the highest religious ideas. In such classical times there is a great unity, or at least a great harmony, in the domain of

spiritual life; the division of labour that sets in at a certain stage of cultural development has not yet made itself felt in this domain. Christianity had such a classical time in the age of the primitive Christian community, and later in the great organizational period at the height of the Middle Ages. A religious problem forms only when other sides of spiritual life—science and art, morality and social life—begin to free themselves and to appear with the claim of having independent value. They then judge religion from their points of view and by their standards, whereas religion in its classical times either simply ignored them—as in the times of origins—or—as in the times of organization—valued them from its own point of view and by its own standard, so that the question became whether these two different evaluations could be brought into mutual harmony.—There must be definite historical conditions present before the religious problem can be posed in a decisive way. It is, if one will, only in unhappy times that a religious problem exists. For this problem is the expression of a spiritual disharmony: the different elements of spiritual life no longer work together in so unified a way as before; they lead in different directions, among which one must perhaps ultimately choose. But then both the necessity and the possibility of an investigation are also present.

That religion is made into a problem will be offensive to many. But thought must have the right to investigate everything, once it has awakened, and only thought itself can mark out its boundaries. Who else should mark out its boundaries? He who perceives no problem has of course no reason to think; but neither has he any reason to prevent others from thinking. He who fears losing his spiritual support must keep away. No one wishes to rob the poor man of his only lamb—but then the poor man must not unnecessarily come dragging it along the highway and demand that traffic be stopped on his account. Experience shows, moreover, that it is rather the oxen than the lambs that loudly announce themselves with their indignation in season and out of season (especially out of season). It is not so much the genuinely poor in spirit as the stiff and blustering dogmatists who take offense when free inquiry claims the right to stir on the religious plane as on any other.

The investigation I wish to undertake here addresses itself neither to those who are finished nor to those who are fearful. The finished are found in every camp, not least among the so-called “freethinkers”—a class of people who, like the “Worms” in Linnaeus’s system, can be characterized only by negative predicates, because the class is supposed to encompass so many different forms. The finished are in possession of a definite negative or positive solution to the religious problem and have thereby lost the sense for further thinking about it. The fearful dare not think about it.—Rather, the

investigation addresses itself to those who are *becoming*. “One who is becoming will always be grateful”—no matter in which direction his becoming goes.

Philosophy is, as is well known, richer in ideas, perspectives, and discussions than in definitive results, and the philosopher would often be in a sorry state if he did not believe that the constant striving after truth belongs to the highest spiritual values, which it is the task of all true religion to uphold. Even if we could learn nothing else from a philosophy-of-religion investigation, we could perhaps learn something about the causes of the strife that rages over religious questions, and about this strife’s significance for the development of spiritual life. And should the religious problem prove insoluble, we might perhaps learn why it is insoluble.

2. The philosophy of religion should not proceed from a finished philosophical system. In a certain sense all thinking must be systematic, for “system” literally means “that which stands together,” and it is an inexorable demand placed on our thoughts that they must be able to “stand together” with one another. There is an inner coherence and consistency which in every domain is the ultimate mark of truth, and which must therefore also be required in the domain of the philosophy of religion. But the philosophy-of-religion enterprise will be most fruitful where religion and its phenomena are not placed in relation to some completed philosophical conception or other, but are illuminated by a philosophizing that is itself in the process of investigating whether a completion is possible at all. The task is to discuss religion’s relation to spiritual life. Religion is itself a kind of or form of spiritual life, and it is judged rightly only when seen in its relation to other kinds or forms. It is no alien standard that is thereby applied to religion. For there is a service from which no spiritual power—even if it appears under the greatest names—can exempt itself, namely to serve the deep and rich development of spiritual life. The philosophy-of-religion task will therefore above all be to find the means for investigating whether religion, under the conditions of our spiritual culture, can continue to render such service. In solving, or better: in treating this task, the philosophy of religion cannot come equipped with other presuppositions than those which every other science brings to the treatment of its subject. Very often it will surely be compelled to declare that there are questions that cannot be answered, because the conditions in the spiritual domain are more complex and more diverse than positive and negative dogmatists suppose. Yet it is not without significance that the problems are discussed. The conscious insight into the impossibility of a solution (*docta ignorantia*) naturally invites one to investigate whether it is then so absolutely necessary that a solution be found. In addition, one’s eye will be sharpened for the particular conditions under which

our spiritual culture lives, and above all for the significance of the division of labour in the spiritual domain, through which the religious problem becomes a special form of the general problem of culture.

A philosophy-of-religion investigation can suitably be arranged so as to consist of an epistemological, a psychological, and an ethical part.

In its classical times, religion satisfies all of humankind's spiritual needs, including its drive for knowledge. Religious ideas then contain for human beings the explanation of existence in its entirety and in its individual parts. But when an independent science has developed, another kind of understanding or explanation appears alongside the religious one, and the question becomes whether these two kinds are compatible. Many hold that the relation is this, that the new, scientific mode of explanation increasingly replaces the religious explanation where particulars are concerned, but that it cannot be applied to existence considered as a whole—to what one customarily calls the “first” or the “last” questions. Then one must discuss whether religion is able to solve the riddles that science cannot solve. If it should then turn out that religious conceptions, whether with respect to the whole or to the particular, cannot help with anything that could rightly be called understanding or explanation, then one must raise the question what significance these conceptions can still have.

This last question leads from the epistemological philosophy of religion to the psychological. For if religious conceptions no longer have cognitive value, the value they might possess must consist in being expressions of sides of the life of the soul other than the intellectual. An attempt must then be made to describe the religious life of the soul, especially the relation of conceptions to religious experience and religious feeling. Through this it will become apparent that religion in its innermost nature has to do not with the understanding of existence but with the *evaluation* of it, and that religious conceptions express the relation in which factual existence, as we know it, stands to that which for us gives life its highest value. The core of religion is—according to the hypothesis to which we are led—a faith in the persistence of value in existence. This faith appears in great, vivid images in the popular religions, especially in the highest among them. Even in those who stand outside every popular religion, such a faith may stir, even though it does not here take definite shape.

The transition from psychological to ethical philosophy of religion is naturally motivated by the question: what ethical value does it have that one believes in the persistence of value? Ethics concerns the production of values, and the possibility cannot be dismissed that the work of producing values leaves no time and no strength for living

in the thought of their persistence. The ethical philosophy of religion forms a parallel to the epistemological. In its classical times, religion directly and indirectly determines the evaluation of all actions and all conditions of life. The religious problem arises on this point when an independent ethics has developed that seeks, by its own path, the grounding and motivation for the evaluation of human actions. And on this point the problem is posed in the sharpest and most pressing way, for the ultimate standard for judging religion must belong to the ethical domain, where the final reckoning of the spiritual account takes place.—

Within the framework here indicated, we shall be able to find room for all essential aspects of the religious problem. I wish to treat this problem not only with the intellectual interest that is aroused by a great and comprehensive subject, but also in the mood that comes from the consciousness of standing before a spiritual form of life in which the human race through millennia has deposited some of its deepest and most inward experiences.

3. Before we enter upon the individual parts of the philosophy of religion, it will be useful to give a somewhat more detailed characterization of the content of the religious problem.

In the Protestant world it is fairly generally acknowledged that one must distinguish between knowledge and faith. The Catholic Church does not acknowledge this distinction in its full extent and therefore does not acknowledge any religious problem in the intellectual domain. It maintains that God's existence can be proved by the paths that Thomas Aquinas, supported by Aristotle, pointed out, and it has even declared it a matter of faith to accept that these proofs suffice. The tradition from the great time of the Middle Ages, when "one did not doubt and was therefore nearer to the truth" (to use a sentence from one of Thomas Aquinas's modern biographers), is continually upheld, and it is not acknowledged that a disharmony has really entered into spiritual life. The distinction between knowledge and faith concedes that such a disharmony is present—that the unity of spiritual life is broken. Is this distinction itself then only a station on the way, in that development will lead to an elimination of all religion from spiritual life, because only that can endure which can enter into a harmonious relation with the other elements of life?—Whether one now assumes that it is only the classical time of religion that is past, or that its time is altogether past, the question cannot be set aside whether spiritual value is lost in the process of dissolution that has set in, or whether a replacement can be found for the spiritual unity and self-containment that was lost. This consideration alone shows that the question of the persistence of value is an essential aspect of the religious problem,

whatever solution one inclines toward. It is not least from this side that philosophy in the last century and a half (from the time of Rousseau, Lessing, and Kant onward) has treated the religious problem. Both Romantics and Positivists have been attentive to this aspect of it.—It must of course be remembered that even if one could show that no spiritual energy was lost in the dissolution of religion, it does not follow that the energy would under the new conditions receive as valuable an application as in the classical times of religion. In the spiritual domain no less than in the material, the conservation of energy is not without further ado the same as the persistence of value. Energy can persist without value persisting, while the reverse cannot well be imagined, since energy in and of itself will be a condition for the persistence and development of what is valuable. Many freethinkers proceed without further ado from the assumption that human life will become more powerful and richer when religion falls away—an assumption that is not self-evident and that rests on the presupposition that psychic equivalents are present—equivalents both in terms of value and in terms of energy. The task will then be to demonstrate these equivalents and thereby establish the persistence of value. But it is a great question and an essential aspect of the religious problem whether such equivalents can be demonstrated.—Moreover, the problem of the persistence of value will also arise within the Church, for religion and the religious life undergo constant changes; and the question becomes whether the values from the classical times of religion persist through these changes—e.g., whether primitive Christianity, both in terms of value and in terms of energy, is preserved in the Christianity of our day. In its sharpest form this problem has appeared in the assertion: “the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists.”—

But the religious problem concerns not only the persistence of value within the human world. It raises not only a psychological but also a cosmological question, namely about the relation between that which stands as the highest value for human beings and the whole of existence. Is there any connection between values and the laws and forces of existence? Are these laws and forces perhaps even ultimately determined by the highest values? Or can we perhaps not ascribe any validity to the concept of value beyond the domain of human life?

The hypothesis that will later (in the psychological philosophy of religion) be sought to be grounded holds that the proposition of the persistence of value is the actual religious axiom, which is expressed in different ways in the different religions and at the different religious standpoints. The religious problem thus concerns the question whether this axiom can really be taken to hold. And at the same time this axiom, insofar as it expresses the fundamental thought of all religion, can be used as a standard for the consistency and

significance of the individual religion or the individual religious standpoint. Finally—as already noted—the relation between ethics and religion can, with the help of this axiom, be expressed in a very simple way: how does faith in the persistence of value relate to the work of finding, producing, and preserving values?—

If the proposition of the persistence of value were to be discussed in its full scope, the discussion would become interminable, and clear starting points for conducting it would soon be lacking. I therefore emphasize at once the limits within which my investigation will move, and which must be kept in mind throughout all that follows.—When I attempt to show that the said proposition is the fundamental thought of all religion, this attempt will not have failed because it turns out that no religion expresses the proposition with clarity and consistency. It will be sufficient if an explicit need or tendency to hold fast to this fundamental thought can be demonstrated, so that the standard for the evaluation of religions in their mutual relations becomes the degree to which they are able to articulate and carry through the proposition.—When the persistence of value is spoken of, this could be understood to mean that value does not vanish, but that there is constantly value in existence, whether it decreases or increases or alternates between decrease and increase. But I understand the expression *the persistence of value* in analogy with the expression *the conservation of energy*, such that the proposition asserts a constant persistence of value through all changes of form. It will perhaps be necessary here to distinguish between potential and actual value, just as one distinguishes between potential and actual energy, and the one distinction is just as clear and just as justified as the other.—But the persistence of value through all changes of form and despite the difference between possibility and actuality is nonetheless only a minimum. It may be maintained that the mere persistence of value is not satisfying and actually contains a contradiction, since value can persist only by growing, since mere repetition dulls, while on the other hand change is valuable only when it brings enhancement. That an increase of value does not conflict with the conservation of energy needs no further demonstration; the increase of value presupposes only a new and more perfect application of energy, not an increase of energy as a whole. It is for the sake of simplicity that I limit the investigation to the persistence of value. And it will also turn out that religious consciousness has at bottom limited itself to this as well. The persistence of value will present us with difficulties and tasks enough, even if we do not enter into everything that lies in the unavoidable consequence that value can persist only if it increases. Yet we must not forget that this consequence is present.—Finally, when the persistence of value is under discussion, one might ask: which value and how much value? I enter into these questions only insofar

as the difference between the different religions and religious standpoints essentially depends on the different answers they give to them. It is clear that the proposition of the persistence of value can be accepted whatever answers one gives. The hypothesis that the persistence of value is the fundamental religious proposition is not shaken by the fact that the different religions and religious standpoints diverge greatly from one another with respect to the character and extent of the valuable in whose persistence they believe.

Value is the property of something that it brings about a real satisfaction or can become the means to such. Value can therefore be immediate or mediate. Immediate value we seek to hold fast when it is given, and to produce when it is not given. We thus make it our end. That we make something an end presupposes, conversely, that we have an experience or a supposition of its immediate value. Mediate value belongs to that which serves the attainment of an end—that is, of an immediate value. Mediate value need not be potential value. For what serves as a means for attaining something of immediate value itself acquires value in our eyes, even though its value stands as derived. There are all possible transitions between mediate and immediate value, and through the shifting of motives the former passes over into the latter, so that what at first had value only as a means now acquires value as an end. Potential value, on the other hand, often means only the possibility that something will acquire value as a means—that is, the possibility of mediate value.—Which values are experienced and therefore acknowledged at the different standpoints will depend on the different character of those standpoints. It is a being's nature that determines its need, and it is its need that determines what acquires value for it. The religious axiom thus shows the necessity of a religion's character being determined by the nature and need of the human beings who profess it. For one cannot seriously believe in the persistence of values that one does not know at least approximately from one's own experience.—

Every application of the concept of value presupposes a relation to a whole whose persistence and development require definite conditions. Such wholes are organisms, personalities, societies, and finally the human race. In an individual whole endowed with consciousness (a personality), feelings of pleasure and displeasure, in all their various degrees and forms, appear as symptoms of a need to maintain or to call forth the conditions of the whole's persistence. Here, then, value is known by immediate experience. But by way of analogy the concept of value—and with it the concept of wholeness, which makes rational discussion of values possible—can be applied to all wholes.—A fuller demonstration than can be given here of the significant connection

between the concepts of value and wholeness I have attempted in *Den menneskelige Tanke* (pp. 238–241; 346–349) and in *Totalitet som Kategori*, ch. 5.

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Chapter 2

Epistemological Philosophy of Religion

2.1 Understanding

Ihm ziemt's die Welt im Innern zu bewegen.

GOETHE.

(It befits him to move the world from within.)

4. Against the supposition I have put forward, that the core of religion is faith in the persistence of value, it might seem to tell that theoretical motives have after all played, and still for many play, a considerable role in the development of religious ideas. I have moreover already remarked that since religion in its classical times is everything for the human being, it in such times also satisfies its drive for knowledge—that is, provides it with means for and forms of understanding and explanation of existence. In the classical times of religion there exists no independent drive for knowledge, any more than special means and forms for satisfying such a drive. The distinction between knowledge and faith, between understanding and evaluation, comes forward only in the critical times—that is, in the times when religion has become a problem. This distinction began to make its way only after a number of violent collisions between religion and science. Only reluctantly has one begun, from the religious side, to learn that it is not religion's business to give us a scientific understanding of the world. What all theologians now repeat, that the Bible is not to teach us natural science, no one would hear when Bruno, Galileo, and Spinoza said it. The persecution of heretics ran its course, and only afterwards did one see the rightness of what the heretics had said. In other domains the same conflict

repeats itself; in our days it is the humanities whose independence is at stake.

Every great religion appears in history with a world-view, in that it gathers up within itself, in a distinctive manner, the whole circle of ideas of its time. Christianity, for example, stood in the first centuries as attractive to many by its intellectual content as well. TATIAN thus went over to Christianity because this “philosophy of the barbarians,” as he called it, seemed to him to explain what he had not before understood: “the coming-to-be of the world.” The old apologists stood generally at the standpoint that Christianity contained the best solution to the riddles of thought. When Plato and other Greek philosophers seemed to hint at similar solutions, this was to be explained, according to Justin Martyr, either by their having been influenced by the Israelite prophets, or else by the fact that “the Word” (Logos), before it became flesh, had worked illuminatingly within human beings. In comparison with the earlier religions, Christianity had—as is generally the case with the higher religions in relation to the lower—a certain rational character, and above all a simplicity, a plain grandeur, which could not but work attractively on many who knew only the earlier religions with their motley mythologies. In so far as the world-view given in the biblical writings was not detailed enough, the Church Fathers and the Schoolmen supplemented it by the aid of Greek science.

Just as Christianity does for the western portion of humanity, so Buddhism stands for the eastern portion not merely as a great religion, but as a great world-view, whose ideas have a certain rational character and cannot be understood without acquaintance with the antecedent Indian thought.

When the opposition between religious and scientific understanding of existence is spoken of, the weight is as a rule laid on the fact that science—especially in the domains of astronomy, geology, and biology—has led to results that conflict with religion’s transmitted teachings. A great part of the work of the modern apologists accordingly goes to showing the compatibility of the transmitted religious ideas with those scientific results that really stand firm. Towards modern natural science one applies, with greater or lesser success—and with greater or lesser taste—the same process of accommodation that the apologists of antiquity applied towards Greek science. But for the illumination of the religious problem as a whole, this entire discussion for and against is of slight interest, except perhaps in so far as it furnishes characteristic examples of the accommodation which the life of religious ideas—like everything living—undergoes, or strives to undergo, in the face of new conditions of life. What is the main matter, on the contrary, is that it is two wholly different kinds or types of “understanding” that here stand over against one another. They are two ways of thinking and of explaining events—two ways so

different that once one has begun with the one, one will not be able to find any point at which it is justified and possible to go over to the other. The whole mental condition is so heterogeneous that the word “understanding” is in reality used here in two wholly different senses. Let me take a single example. A sudden storm and tidal flood, which brings about the destruction of many fishermen at sea, is explained in natural-scientific fashion by the states of the air and the sea in the preceding days. But in the funeral oration over the drowned, the “understanding” of what has happened is found in this, that God wished to give the survivors a sign, that they should be converted.¹ At what point in the series of natural causes can one now suppose that this divine intervention has taken place? The natural causes form a connected series, from which no link can be taken out. A choice must be made between the two “understandings.” The one kind of understanding aims, so far as possible, to form connected series of links, each of which can be pointed out in experience. The more the state of the air and the sea at the moment of the catastrophe has been brought into connected sequence with their states in the preceding days, the better—according to the one type of understanding—one is said to understand the catastrophe. According to the other type, it is understood by the value it acquires through its influence on the minds of those who suffer under it, and this value is regarded as intended—as the purpose of a divine intervention.

The scientific type of understanding has developed in a clear and fruitful manner especially in the course of the last three centuries. It does not exclude a religious evaluation, but it excludes a confusion of this evaluation with explanation proper. It is the task of philosophical epistemology to investigate the presuppositions and the forms of thought that lie at the foundation of scientific knowledge, and it will be of philosophy-of-religion interest to bring out these presuppositions and forms of thought and to compare them with the foundation of religious “understanding.” Through this we shall be able to obtain information as to how far religion will still be able to have significance for the satisfaction of our drive for knowledge.

2.1.1 Causal Explanation

5. When one sets up the proposition that every event has its cause—the so-called causal principle—one thereby establishes the principle that existence is intelligible. This proposition can never become more than a hypothesis, since we can never understand everything, never point out causes for all events. But it contains the presupposition with which we involuntarily meet events that awaken our attention; at any rate it is the presupposition that brings us to look about for earlier events when an event has

occurred.

We can here disregard entirely the question of the causal principle's justification and origin, since the mutually divergent conceptions here offered need not acquire any philosophy-of-religion significance. Whether the acknowledgement of this proposition is due to habit or to an inner necessity in our nature, the need to find causes stirs more or less in everyone, and the religious conception bears witness to it as well as the scientific. Indeed, religious ideas have a peculiar epistemological interest precisely in this, that they testify how deeply the need to find causes lies in human nature, since it expresses itself even there where no independent scientific interest has yet arisen. The opposition between religion and science comes forward only when regard is had to the *character* of the causes one acknowledges as right, real causes (*veræ causæ*). *Both religious and scientific understanding are a leading back of the unknown to the known; the difference between them rests on what this known is.*

Scientific understanding requires that the cause of an event be demonstrated in events that themselves establish themselves in experience just as well as the event to be explained. The task here becomes to interpret the series of events by finding as many individual links in this series, and as close a connection between them, as possible. The aim is to interpret nature by nature itself, just as one interprets a passage in a book by comparing it with other passages in the same book. Religious understanding does not make the demand that the cause should stand in continuous connection with the effect and itself be demonstrated as an experience just as well as the event to be explained. It does not investigate its causes in the critical manner that science does. It does not explain nature by nature itself, but by something that is different from or stands outside nature, that "pushes in from without." Thus, at any rate, religious understanding most frequently appears in history. In contrast to this religious understanding, the special form that empirical science—in both the mental and the material domains—gives to the causal principle can be designated as *the principle of natural causes*. If it cannot be applied, we understand nothing, when it is the scientific type of understanding and the corresponding intellectual habit that prevail in us.

Only the principle of natural causes satisfies the need for a special explanation of the particular, determinate event. Galileo thus showed that in the debate between the different contending astronomical hypotheses it could be of no use to appeal to God's intervention, since for God's omnipotence it is just as easy to let the sun move round the earth as to let the earth move round the sun. This cause therefore cannot help us to a choice between the hypotheses. It is a key that unlocks everywhere; but it is not such a

master key that science seeks; science's interest is to investigate the peculiar character of the different locks, and it therefore demands a key of its own for every lock. If a master key were sufficient, the difference of the locks would become meaningless—and would contain an unsolved problem!—To appeal to God's will gives no scientific understanding, but is—scientifically regarded—an admission that one does not understand the event.

The deepest justification for the principle of natural causes I find in a need for continuity, which lies in the nature of our consciousness and which already shows itself in the general need to find causes. Our consciousness strives involuntarily to gather up and hold together its elements and to preserve unity with itself, even when it stands before a new content. This new content it then strives to shape, alter, and arrange, so that the new shows itself to be a new form of something old. Self-recognition then becomes possible in spite of the shifting of content, and the unity of the personal life mirrors itself in the continuity thereby brought about. The work of knowledge is here closely bound up with the work on the development of character. We speak of a character—in the pronounced sense—only where unity and continuity prevail in the whole striving, and where there is not again and again a leaping over to something new. In analogy with this, knowledge seeks to find as much unity and continuity as possible, to exhibit the new as a transformation or continuation of the old; and only where this succeeds is a full appropriation and understanding won. The principle of natural causes, which leads one to build series as long and as continuous as possible, is therefore no accident, but is closely bound up with the very nature of personality. It is therefore incorrect when personality and science are set in sharp opposition to one another. Scientific work is a work of personality. And the more this work succeeds, the more does causal explanation approach grounding and recognition. The differences in existence are reduced to the least possible when we survey, at a single glance, “under the form of eternity,” great regions of existence.

Religious understanding too—in the mythical and dogmatic forms in which it most frequently appears in history—leads the unknown back to the known. But this known is here as a rule the will of one or more personal beings. The religious consciousness supposes itself to know what the divine will aims at, and recognizes in events the expression of this will. Its interest is not to find an inner connection among events themselves, but to see all events (in the whole of nature, or in some single domain) as the expression of one and the same power. It places itself at the centre, or supposes itself to be at the centre, and from there it surveys the whole circle of existence.

The difficulty for the religious conception here becomes this, that the radius with

which this circle is described is not known. From one and the same centre many different circles can be described. Therefore every “central” consideration (as it has moreover been attempted not only on religious presuppositions, but also in speculative philosophical form) will be powerless with respect to the understanding of the special events. A theological or speculative epistemology will therefore not be able to be carried through. There do not even exist serious attempts at one; but we must hold to the epistemology that empirical and critical philosophy has developed on the basis of the history of empirical science.

6. When the scientific type of understanding has begun to prevail, but is excluded at certain selected points where religious understanding still claims dominion, there arises the bastard concept called wonder, *miracle*. The miracle presupposes that both types make themselves felt, but that there is a leap over from the one type to the other. Where either a certain degree of scientific understanding or of knowledge is not present, the miracle can only mean a deviation from the accustomed. The natural man wonders when the hitherto unseen or unheard-of happens. But the miracle proper presupposes a certain knowledge of natural laws—a continuity that is broken—a rule from which an exception is made. Miracles must therefore occur according to the law of parsimony; if they come so frequently that they become the rule, they form a continuous connection, and the concept of miracle is abolished.

If one does not set up the principle of natural causes in a wholly dogmatic manner, one cannot maintain in advance the impossibility of miracles. But the decisive thing is here again the way the problem is posed and the intellectual habit. For him who asks and sets up his problems according to the scientific type, for him a miracle can never come to be. He may come to stand before something he cannot explain, since no cause (in the sense in which he speaks of cause) can be found, or at any rate has hitherto been found. But he can never discover that there is no natural cause. The religious consciousness itself cannot—without ascribing omniscience to itself—maintain that an event *cannot* be explained according to natural laws. To know that something falls outside the laws of nature, one must know them all and know all possible special applications of them. Only by a revelation could one come to know that in the particular case a miracle is present. It is not the miracle that confirms the revelation, but the revelation that decides what is a miracle. And since a revelation is itself a miracle, one can only by a miracle come to know whether a miracle has happened.—It is consistent when the Catholic Church, which decides what is revelation, also demands to decide what is a miracle and what is not. Nothing may be taken for a miracle unless it is sanctioned as such by “apostolic and

ordained authority.”²

In the case of miracles of which one is not oneself an eyewitness, the question will particularly be whether the report is so securely transmitted, and whether the eyewitness has been so keen an observer, that one will sooner be able to assume a deviation from the laws of nature than an error in transmission and observation. A report that does not derive from an observer who has sufficient acquaintance with the natural conditions and natural laws in question has no scientific significance.

7. The preceding consideration rested on the scientific concept of cause, according to which an event is understood by being seen in its inner connection with other events, as a continuation of them or as a transformation into new form of their content. The presupposition of all such causal explanation is a principle of unity that makes connection possible. We reach this principle by analysis of the very concept of causal connection or reciprocal action. It is the bond that holds existence together and makes it a whole, more than a chaos of elements—even if it is a whole we cannot survey.

The principle of unity at which we have thus arrived recalls the concept of God. But the customary line of thought often reaches its concept of God by another road: not by going back to the presupposition of the causal series, to the principle that makes such a series possible at all, but by continuing the causal series backwards to a “first cause.” By virtue of this line of thought one will say, in the face of the preceding development: “Religion gladly leaves it to science—a few supernatural events excepted—to find the finite causes and to spin out the causal series as far as possible. The causes that science can find are nevertheless always subordinate, derived causes (*causæ secundæ*). What religion maintains is that existence becomes meaningless if we do not at last find the origin of the whole causal series in a first cause, an absolute cause, in which thought finds rest—where all further questioning falls away—and from which the full, clear light streams out over everything.”

This line of thought stems from ARISTOTLE and is taken up by THOMAS AQUINAS, on whose authority it is still espoused by Catholic theology,³ as well as by many Protestant theologians. It is the so-called cosmological proof of God’s existence—the most important of all “proofs”—that we here stand before.

That the series of causes must be limited is inferred from the consideration that otherwise no complete explanation of any link whatever in the series of events would have been reached. “If there is no first,” says ARISTOTLE, “there is no cause at all.” It is thus the condition of existence’s intelligibility that one here supposes oneself to be relying on. It is a rationalistic tendency that lies at the foundation of this theological

line of thought. Existence must be comprehensible!—that is the underlying postulate. Aristotle does not, however, assume that the first cause began to work at a definite point of time, so that “the world” has a beginning. And Thomas also concedes that it is only by the way of faith that one comes to assume that the world has a beginning (*mundum incepisse, sola fide tenetur*).

KANT has subjected this proof to a criticism that leads him to the result that it rests on “a false self-satisfaction of human reason.” In the main his criticism stands in force to this very day. In what follows I make use in part of his objections, adding to them some other misgivings.

Even if we could build a connected causal series, at what point should we then break off our search for finite causes in order to hang the whole chain on a “first cause”—as Zeus in Homer threatens to hang the whole world on a peak of Mount Olympus? What mark can we have that we are at the “next to first” cause, so that we must now set about making the decisive leap?—And why should the causal series not be able to be infinite? That an infinite series is unthinkable is a dogmatic assertion. There can be series which, by virtue of the law that holds for the relation between their links, can always be continued. Such series we think—not by running through all the links, which is of course impossible—but by thinking the law of their connection. Such a series is the causal series. It is built by virtue of the causal principle, which says that everything that happens has its cause. This proposition must—if it is accepted at all—also be accepted as holding for every single link in the series, for the “first” one has gone back to as well as for all the others. The assumption of an absolutely first cause would thus conflict with the causal principle—although it was precisely to be justified by existence’s absolute intelligibility, and so by the causal principle!—

Popular theology will especially hold to the form of the cosmological proof that runs thus: “Since everything has its cause, the world too must have its cause.” One operates here with the concept “world” without noticing that it contains the same or similar difficulties as those that just showed themselves in the concept of God. If by “world” one understands the sum total of all that exists, or at any rate of all “finite” existing things, then it is a concept that can never be completed. The given is never completed; new experiences are always coming in, which make new conceptual determinations necessary. We therefore never come, by the road of scientific inquiry, to a point at which there could be a question of a cause of “the whole world.” The given constitutes a whole, which we analyse in order to find its laws and its elements; but every given whole points over to other wholes; we seek to work all given wholes together into a still higher whole;

but however far this work be continued, the same task will always present itself anew. There is here a series of like kind with the causal series—a series that by virtue of its own law cannot be completed. The concept “world” is therefore properly a false concept, though one operates with it so briskly, plays with it as with a ball.

2.1.2 The World of Space

8. When the religious consciousness historically shows a tendency to limit the series of causes, this is in part to be explained by the need for intuitive vividness. The religious consciousness wants a vivid image of its object, and such an image presupposes limitation. With this in turn hangs together its tendency to refer the divine to definite places in space. Spatial ideas are our clearest ideas, and what we wish to represent clearly we therefore seek to shape into spatial images or schemata. With this there naturally combines the idea that everything that exists must belong at a definite place in the world, must be localized. What is not at some definite place seems, to the childlike conception, which is decidedly realistic, not to be at all. Just as, with respect to the explanation of the world, it would be the simplest thing if we could come upon the deity by following the series of causes link by link, so also, with respect to the conception of the world, it would be the simplest thing if the human being needed only to lift his eyes upward to find the deity, or at any rate could behold its dwelling.

Antiquity's conception of the world met this need. For it the world was limited. The earth stood at the world's centre, and the vault of heaven, which was not thought to be extraordinarily far off, formed the world's outermost boundary. The bright sky has, especially for the Indo-Germanic peoples, been regarded as deity or as the seat of the deity. The stem from which many of the Indo-Germanic languages form their word for “God” properly denotes sky or heavenly. Thus the Indian *devas*, the Persian *deva*, the Greek Ζεύς (Δίος), the Latin *deus*, and so on. Herodotus says of the Persians that they call the sky Zeus, and with this agrees the fact that the natural background of the god Ahura Mazda (Ormuzd) is assumed by the more recent history of religion to be the sky. The Greeks supposed, indeed, in the oldest time, that the gods dwelt more particularly on Mount Olympus, but later thought of the sky or “the aether” as their dwelling. Aristotle says: “All human beings assume that there are gods, and all, both barbarians and Hellenes, assign to the deity the uppermost place.” The opposition between heaven and earth thus became quite naturally, for antiquity, one with the opposition between the divine and the human, between the eternal and the changeable, between the perfect and the imperfect. The expressions “the higher” and “the lower” had originally a literal meaning;

the symbolic meaning is here, as everywhere, the later one. Aristotle's incorporation of antiquity's astronomical conception into his system became of decisive importance. Since both this conception and his whole system seemed to be compatible with the biblical circle of ideas, and capable of serving for the further working-out of it, they were taken up by ecclesiastical theology and through it became dominant right into the modern age.

Among the Jewish people too we meet with the great religious significance of the opposition between heaven and earth. In the opinion of some, Jahveh was originally a thunder-god; at any rate he reveals himself with special majesty in the heavenly phenomena. Heaven is his seat, and the earth his footstool. The New Testament conception stands here entirely on the ground of the Old. There is sometimes talk of several heavens (2 Corinthians XII, 2; Ephesians IV, 10), and God's dwelling is then the heavenly holy of holies, which is above all the heavens. Accounts such as that of Jesus's visible ascension and of Paul's rapture to the third heaven testify that the ancient picture of the world is presupposed. As these accounts stand, they are plainly to be taken literally, though the more recent theology (even the orthodox) is on this point inclined to apply the rationalistic explanation.

There was both vividness and security in the narrow frame within which the picture of the world thus presented itself. Without being disturbed and disquieted by infinite distances, the religious consciousness could give itself wholly to the great experiences of life and regard the all-decisive process of redemption—resolved on in heaven and accomplished on earth—as that about which the whole outer life of the world also turned. There was as it were a ladder between heaven and earth; the two worlds, the world of the highest value and the world of contending values, stood in vivid reciprocal action. Poets like Homer and Dante are testimony to what foothold and what support the limited picture of the world afforded the human imagination.

But within the religious consciousness itself there shows itself, at a somewhat higher stage of development, an opposite tendency, which at the cost of vividness aims at abolishing the localization of the content of religious ideas. It came to appear an imperfection that the deity should really have its dwelling at a definite place, so that it must either move through space in order to come to the human being, or the human being must travel long roads to meet his God. God must be omnipresent and all-embracing if he is not to be limited and imperfect, as a human being is. However short the distance between heaven and earth was thought to be, it nevertheless became too long for the religious need. The deity had to stand in a far more intimate relation to the human being

than localization at definite places made possible.

In the biblical writings and among the ecclesiastical theologians we find, then, a double current. Vividness is held fast; but where it is the inwardness of feeling, rather than the imagination's need for intuition, that leads the word, there the significance of the spatial relation is abolished. God dwells in heaven—but he is truly not far from us, for in him we are and live and move. Jesus ascends to heaven and shall come thence again—but he lives in believers and is with them all their days.

The religious conception has here, in its classical times, a *Both—And*, which later is gradually replaced by an *Either—Or*.

9. What made it possible for the theologians of earlier times to hold fast to this Both—And was the bold use they made of allegorical or symbolic interpretation. An allegorical interpretation did not, according to their conception, exclude the literal meaning. The relation between the two remained in a certain indeterminacy, which not seldom could lead to violent collisions. "There was lacking," says ADOLF HARNACK in his history of dogma, "a definite rule for how far the letter of Holy Scripture should hold. Has God human shape, has he eyes, has he a voice, does Paradise lie on the earth, do the dead rise with all their limbs, with hair too, and so on?—to all these questions and a hundred like them no certain answer was given, and therefore there was strife between the adherents of one and the same confession. Allegorize all had to, but all had on the other hand also to take certain passages of Scripture literally. But what a difference there was between an Epiphanius and a Gregory of Nyssa, and how many nuances there were between the crude anthropomorphists and the spiritualists! These last for the most part feared the arguments of the former, often also their fists, and they had to be anxious about their own orthodoxy."⁴

AUGUSTINE is certainly the one who has contributed most to displacing the merely literal conception. His Platonic studies have here had decisive influence and have—in conjunction with his profound and strongly agitated inner life—led him to a clearer view of the difference between the spiritual and the material, and thereby led him to utter thoughts in which he stands as the precursor of Descartes and Kant. What in this connection especially interests us is his rejection of all spatial determinations as invalid for the divine. Where he speaks of his own earlier conception, he says: "I did not know that God is a spirit that has no limbs with length and breadth, any more than bodily mass (*moles*). The bodily (*moles*) is less in a part than in the whole, and if it is infinite, it is less in a limited part than in the infinite, and it is not everywhere as a whole (*tota ubiqve*), as God is." "God is present in his wholeness everywhere, and is yet nowhere in

place (*ubique totus, et nusquam locorum*)!” “God dwells further within my being than my own inmost self, and he is more exalted than the highest I can reach (*interior intimo meo, superior summo meo*).” “God stands above my soul, but not in the same way as heaven stands above the earth.”⁵

When thoughts such as these were appropriated and carried through, they had to lead to strife with the old picture of the world and its childlike opposition between heaven and earth. The Schoolmen of the Middle Ages held fast to the immaterial concept of God, independent of spatial determinations, and from them it passed over to the Mystics, who besides were influenced by Neoplatonic thoughts.—“Lord,” Suso’s female disciple asks him, “where is God?” The answer runs: “The masters say: God has no Where.... God is a circle whose centre is everywhere and whose circumference is nowhere.”⁶ Thus, through inner contradiction, the validity of the spatial relation is abolished.

Towards accounts such as that of the visible ascension one took up in the Middle Ages this position: that one held fast that the events reported had taken place as they were described, but that they had a spiritual meaning which was the essential thing. HUGH OF ST. VICTOR explains that by “the highest” is meant the inmost in us, and that ascending to God means that we sink ourselves into ourselves and there find something that is “higher” than ourselves. But he will not therefore deny that heaven and hell are definite places in the world. His contemporary ABELARD maintains (in his remarkable “Dialogue between a Philosopher, a Jew, and a Christian”) that what is said of God in bodily form is to be understood—not, as the common man understands it, bodily and literally—but mystically and allegorically. By heaven’s exaltation above the earth is meant rather the exalted character (*sublimitas*) of the life to come than the situation of the material heaven, and that Jesus sits at God’s right hand denotes not a spatial position (*localis positio*), but equality of dignity (*æqualis dignitas*). Jesus’s ascension has indeed taken place bodily as it is reported, but it denotes nevertheless “a nobler kind of ascent” (*melior ascensus*), namely that which takes place in the souls of believers. Unlearned and simple people would not understand what is not presented in vivid form.⁷

The characteristic Both—And here comes clearly forward. It had its great advantages in a pedagogical respect, since one did not need to make any sharp distinction between idea and reality, symbol and truth. With his bodily eyes the human being could look up to heaven, the seat of power and grace, but the same heaven he had in the inner states in which the divine made known its authority and bestowed its consolation. The evangelical narratives could be taken according to the letter and yet at the same time be interpreted spiritually and edifyingly. The absolute differences of place in the world of

space appeared immediately as the expression of differences of value.

10. There came, however, the time when one had to choose. There arose a conflict between an idealistic conception, which inculcates the purely spiritual significance of religious ideas, and a realistic or materialistic conception, which held to vividness and literalness. Such a conflict is known in many religions. In the *Upanishads*, the idealistic interpretation of the Vedic religion, it is said that Bráhma, the deity, is imperishable, while “name, place, time, and body” perish, wherefore none of these determinations holds for Bráhma. In Xenophanes’s and Plato’s criticism of the Greek popular faith a similar tendency shows itself. Within Mohammedanism it comes forward when, for example, the sensuous and vivid depiction of the joys of Paradise is interpreted allegorically as a presentation of spiritual enjoyments.⁸

When it began to dawn on thought that there are no absolute determinations of place, since every place is determined by its relation to other places, these again by their relation to others, and so forth, the old picture of the world was moving towards its dissolution. It went with the series of places as it went with the series of causes; one could not get the series absolutely completed, so that the picture could be bounded. And when now Copernicus showed that the simplest picture of the world was obtained by thinking of the earth as moving round the sun, so that it was no longer the world’s centre, there fell away the clear and secure frame within which the content of religious ideas had hitherto been able to be localized. It was besides soon shown—by Giordano Bruno—that it was inconsistent to hold fast to the limitation of “the world” when one accepted the relativity of all determinations of place and the Copernican astronomy. An infinite horizon opened.⁹ The difference between heaven and earth fell away, and an Either—Or had to replace the earlier Both—And: only the idealistic meaning of the word “heaven” was now tenable, if this word was to express a religious idea.

To this there now came also another movement of thought. Just as one had hitherto found spiritual differences of value expressed in a vivid way by spatial distances, so one had generally made no sharp difference between the spiritual and the material. With the beginning of natural science this difference came forward more clearly, and it came—with Kepler and Descartes—to stand as a chief mark of the material that it is extended in space. It had now to become a special problem, not merely how the spiritual and the material stand related to one another, but also whether the spiritual world is as comprehensive as the material world, according to the new picture of the world, showed itself to be. The security with which one had hitherto been able to find spiritual things expressed in material forms was quite particularly shaken by this. Formerly one had

been able literally to see “spirits”; after the Cartesian reform of psychology this was no longer possible. The spiritual world came to stand in opposition to the world of space, of extension, and of vividness, however one might think of the inner relation between them. Everything vivid could now at last, that is to say, from a religious point of view, acquire only symbolic significance.

But it was easier for philosophy than for theology to draw this consequence. With thinkers like Bruno and Spinoza the religious ideas underwent an inwardization and an infinitization that corresponded to the new conception of the world and carried further what Augustine and the Mystics had already hinted at. After long resistance and misgiving, theology began to strike into the same road. And often we now see the assertion put forward that the idealistic meaning of such expressions as “heaven” (or “hell,” and so on) is the only valid one, and the only one that the Bible and the Church have ever approved. CARDINAL NEWMAN declares, for example, that the Council of Trent does not teach that Purgatory causes sensuous pain, though he concedes that this was the Latin Church’s tradition, and that he himself has seen in the streets of Naples paintings that represented souls burning in Purgatory. But in an ecclesiastically sanctioned handbook on the doctrine of Purgatory the question is raised: “Is the flame of Purgatory really a bodily flame?” And to this it is said: “Cardinal Bellarmine answers that the general opinion of theologians is that the flame of Purgatory is a true and real flame, of the same kind as our earthly fire.” And it is added that the great majority of Church Fathers, Schoolmen, and theologians teach that Purgatory, like hell, is found at the earth’s centre, and that this doctrine is built on Holy Scripture and has always been maintained by the Church.¹⁰—Here idealism and realism stand sharply over against one another. One may by particular distinctions seek to veil the breach in spiritual development that let an Either—Or replace a Both—And (just as this had in its time replaced the immediate, childlike localization); but history will always bring it forth anew, and it is of the very greatest importance for the right understanding of the religious problem that it not be forgotten.

By the Copernican and the Cartesian reform there have been drawn more definite boundaries than could be drawn before, between thought and intuition, reality and symbolism. The philosophy-of-religion significance of this is easy to see. Of quite special significance is the expansion of the world, the infinite horizons that the material world has gained, and in relation to which the spiritual world now seems to be so limited. How will one—the question arose naturally—now be able to hold fast to the conviction that spiritual values are the highest thing in existence, that about which everything turns?

Now the outer world no longer turns about the home of the only spiritual life we know from experience!—There arose an opposition between psychology and cosmology which the past did not know. Great spirits like JACOB BÖHME and BLAISE PASCAL felt keenly the problem that lay in this, and which in religion's classical times could not be posed.—It is not, however, only for positive religion that a great, perhaps insoluble problem is here posed. For every view of life the same problem must present itself in one form or another. Naturally there are problems at all only for those who have not from indolence or anxiety given up thinking. To the problem itself we shall later return.

2.1.3 The Course of Time

2.2 Concluding Thoughts

2.3 Thought and Image

Chapter 3

Psychological Philosophy of Religion

3.1 Religious Experience and Religious Faith

3.1.1 Religious Experience

3.1.2 Religious Faith

3.2 The Development of Religious Ideas

3.2.1 Religion as Drive

3.2.2 Polytheism and Monotheism

3.2.3 Religious Experience and Tradition

3.2.4 The Scientific Conclusion of the Psychology of Religion

3.3 Dogmas and Symbols

3.4 The Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.4.1 More Precise Determination of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value and of its Relation to Experience

3.4.2 Psychological-Historical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.4.3 General Philosophical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.5 The Principle of Personality

Chapter 4

Ethical Philosophy of Religion

4.1 Religion as the Foundation of Ethics

4.2 Religion as a Form of Spiritual Culture

4.2.1 Psychological Considerations

4.2.2 Sociological Considerations

4.3 Primitive Christianity and Modern Christianity

4.4 We Live on Realities

Notes